



CLIENT BALANCES

ASSETS

ACCESS

C\$215M
OWED

CLAIMS

QUADRIGACX

052 / JAN-APR 2019 / EXCHANGES / COMMON

BALANCES WITHOUT BACKING.

On January 14, 2019, Canadian crypto exchange QuadrigaCX announced that co-founder and CEO Gerald Cotten had died the previous month. The platform shut down, obtained creditor protection on February 5 and moved into bankruptcy in April. For clients who had trusted those account balances, the urgent question became how much money remained.

OSC staff's later reconstruction put the amount owed to over 76,000 clients at approximately C\$215 million. Ernst & Young recovered or identified about C\$46 million in assets, leaving a C\$169 million shortfall. These are retrospective report figures, not a claim that all recoveries were complete during January-April 2019.

Staff attributed most of the shortfall to Cotten's fraudulent conduct. Their analysis traced roughly C\$115 million to his trading on Quadriga using invented balances, and another C\$28 million to losses on outside platforms. Real client assets covered the losses, while incoming deposits were used to meet other clients' withdrawals.

The familiar story of a dead founder and inaccessible keys explained too little. In staff's assessment, the business was already deeply insolvent before Cotten died. The missing assets could not largely be explained by losing access to wallets after his death. These are OSC staff findings and views, not findings tested before a tribunal or court.

The artwork turns that gap into a fictional archive: a huge sheet of client balances faces a small, damaged asset sheet. Claims gather below, and a safe sits to one side. The central problem is the distance between the obligations on the books and the assets available to honour them.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 THE BALANCE SHEETS

The oversized client ledger and small asset sheet visualise the imbalance. Their torn edges are symbolic; they do not depict actual destroyed records or establish how evidence was handled.

02 C\$215M OWED

The bundle names the approximate Canadian-dollar value owed to clients in the OSC reconstruction. It represents liabilities, not a pile of cash or the amount locked inside the safe.

03 THE CLAIMS BOX

The files stand for affected clients seeking recovery. They are invented props, not copies of actual claim forms. The figure holding a folder is a fictional adult, not an identified claimant.

04 THE HIDDEN KEY NOTE

A printed key note is tucked among folders below the balances sheet. It recalls the access narrative as a secondary clue, not a discovered usable key. OSC staff attributed most losses to misconduct.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Sources: OSC staff review: executive summary; OSC: Where did the funds go?; EY trustee factum: chronology, paragraph 3. The archive, person, papers, printed key note and safe are fictional symbolic imagery, not a documented location, person or evidence scene. Torn papers do not imply actual destruction of records. "BALANCES WITHOUT BACKING." is original editorial wording, not a historical quotation. The OSC account records staff views, not adjudicated findings.